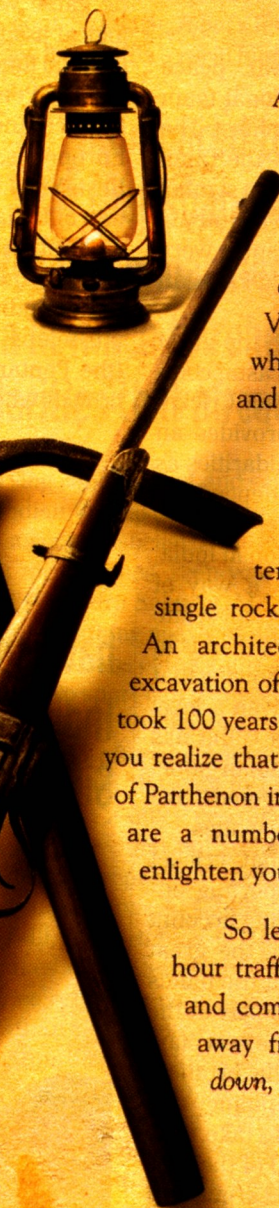




ON HUNTING EXPEDITIONS, PEOPLE USUALLY
come back with rabbits, deer, wild boars and pigeons.
WELL, A CERTAIN CAPTAIN JOHN SMITH CAME BACK
with a piece of history.

Not always does one stumble upon something that creates history. And that too of such magnificent proportions. Just what Captain John Smith did way back in 1819 when he stumbled upon a hidden cave on his way to a tiger hunting expedition. Little did he know that what he came across would open a whole new chapter in the history of the world, leave alone India. This "accidental" discovery was none other than the famous Ajanta Caves.

A historic marvel, Ajanta's history goes back more than two thousand years ago around 2nd Century BC, when followers of Gautama Buddha retired here to a lonely precipice. There they dug into the rocks and carved out nearly 30 marvellous temples and dwelling halls over a period of more than 600 years. What's more surprising is that they achieved this rare feat with just the help of a few mallets and chisels. Today, in spite of the ravages of time and vagaries of nature, the colours of the frescoes still glow. Flowers two thousand years old sparkle like jewels, vivid figures move with life, gift bearing ladies serve godlike kings.



And if that's not enough to satisfy the adventurer in you, head to the historical Ellora Caves. A mere 84 kilometers from Ajanta, Ellora is a marvel of architectural extravagance, inspired by the Vajrayana school of Buddhism, which was rich in symbolism of magic and mysticism.

Like Ajanta, Ellora has a number of magnificent masterpieces such as the Kailasnatha Temple. A temple which is carved out of a single rock, and that too with bare hands. An architectural wonder, it entailed the excavation of over 200,000 tonnes of rock and took 100 years to complete. Not surprising, once you realize that it covers an area double the size of Parthenon in Athens. Apart from these, there are a number of sculptures and caves to enlighten you and mystify your senses.

So leave those hectic schedules, rush hour traffic and stressful deadlines behind and come to a land that takes you miles away from the maddening rush. Slow down, take a break, rediscover yourself.



Incredible India

